1 Making and growing a character

Your character

- **Archetypes and Titles:** two to start. Each one gets a Title you name for it and three permissions, six at most, and the Title counts 1 where it fits. You can take the same archetype twice. The new one you get past d12 on your Aspiration starts with one permission.
- **Traits:** two, on their own, and Grow can give you more.
- **Permissions:** one word, like *Deceptive*, or a doing word and how, what or where, like *climb sheer walls*. It's 1 step on a roll it fits, once a roll, and it goes on two set actions at most. You need a magic permission or a magic item to do magic at all, and magic's written narrow.
- **Boons:** two permission slots on a Title buy one. Burdens only come on attuned things. The menu's in Boons and Burdens.
- **Aspiration:** starts at d2 and climbs. An action when it's within reach, or a slot. One step a roll.
- **Defend:** a set action like the rest, with a line for each piece of plain armour and a shield. **Confidence:** d6 at the start of every scene (see Confidence).
- **To start:** 5 Aura, 2 Resolve (one for each Title), a stride of 3, a wound die at d2, one attuned thing, and two bond threads with the crew.

Things that climb

- Things that climb (the Goal, Aspirations, projects, agendas) start low, step up on a win, one step a roll, and past d12 they're done.

Downtime

- Four pressures: personal, party, faction, world. Ignore one and it gets worse, and twice makes it a scene. Every faction's action is telegraphed at the start, and rolled after the slots.
- Two personal slots each, and the crew takes one action, like any faction. A personal slot can go into the crew's action. All your Resolve comes back, and your wound die goes back to d2, or to your Scars.
- **Recover:** mend something broken. **Grow:** a new permission on a Title · a new trait or thread · chase your Aspiration · get something.
- **Mend a thread** you've strained by making it right with them. Downtime's one place for it, and a scene with them is the other.
- **Swap** a permission for another that fits your Title, or two for a Boon, and back. **Attune:** a slot for each new permission, and the material for a new stage. A soul you're carrying goes into your summoning attunement.
- Ties go to the defender. No Aura: spend 1 Resolve to roll your dice again, or an extra crew resource to take the tie.

Bonds and threads

- A bond's usually a person, but it can be a faction, a place or a cause. Each thread is one truth between you, and it's a **bond thread**, something good, or a **hostile thread**, something gone bad. Either can be strained, which means nearly snapped, and with no thread at all you're neutral.
- **To start:** two bond threads with the crew, from your answers in Connect. Write a hostile thread too and you can write a third bond thread, and three's the most.
- **Borrow** through a bond thread: 1 Aura brings their permission into your roll (a faction's, one of its assets), and it doesn't strain anything. Not while it's strained.
- **Strain** a bond thread: lean on them in the story and take 1 Resolve. It's free and takes no action, and the thread's strained. One with someone in the crew is strained for both of you.
- **Mend:** make it right with them, in downtime or in a scene with them (not the fight where you strained it), and it's whole again.
- **Snap:** strain it again before it's mended. You still take the Resolve, but cross the thread out. When the last one goes, so does the bond.
- **A hostile thread** bites like a Catch: when it brings you real trouble, 1 Aura, or 1 Resolve for a big bite. Doing right by them strains it, and doing it again snaps it.

Confidence

- **Every scene starts on d6.** Clothes that fit the scene start you a size up, and so do the Boon and traits that say so. The Burden starts you a size down. At the end of the scene you rest with it (see Wounds), then it goes back to d6, and anything that should last is a Hurt.
- **Fear is a telegraph.** The GM telegraphs fear, lies and pressure at your Confidence like any attack, and you answer it or let it ride. Nobody can intercept it, but a Bard's song can stop it for the crew.
- **Up a size:** for each telegraph your Defend or Confidence stops, and for each action where one of your dice wins (in a combo, everyone who put an action in). Taking a breath brings it up a size too, as far as d6.
- **Down a size:** each time your wound die steps up (not when your armour or kit takes the blow), for each action where all your dice miss, and when fear, lies or pressure get through, unless 1 Resolve holds your ground.
- **Nothing takes it below d2:** fear, lies or pressure that get through on d2 are a Hurt instead, or 1 Resolve to hold your ground, and anything else leaves it on d2.
- **d12, fired up:** cash it in for an extra action, or to bring your wound die down a size, and it drops back to d6. It never goes higher than d12.
- **d2, shaken:** you can't take an action at what the scene's about unless you spend 1 Resolve each time. Otherwise your action goes on pulling yourself together, back up to d4.

Wounds and healing

- Your wound die starts at d2, one die for body and mind. Every Hurt puts it up a size, as far as d12. A vulnerability that fits the hit makes it one more Hurt.
- **Rest:** at the end of every scene, roll the Confidence you finished on against your wound die. Beat it and your wound comes down a size. Downtime clears it.
- **Blaze:** take a Hurt at d12 and declare something extraordinary. It happens, no roll. You can choose to die. If you don't, leave the scene, and the wound's a Scar: a Catch, and your wound die never goes below a size for each one (d4 with one). Five Scars, and your next Blaze is your last.
- **Heal** (the Healer's): an action against the patient's wound die. Each die that beats it brings it down a size, never below their Scars. It reaches one person, and a split can reach a second person you can touch.
- **Quick heal**, for anyone: 1 Aura brings one person's wound die down a size, no roll, and it still takes your action.

2 Archetypes, Aura and the round

The archetypes

On most of them, 1 Aura puts +2 on one die of the mechanic after you roll, and taking the same archetype twice makes it +3. Every one has a Resolve spend too, something big for 1 Resolve. The whole of each one is in The Archetypes.

- **Bard:** your action lifts every friend who can hear you a size of Confidence, as far as d10, or your song's a Defend against fear for all of them, with its lines counting twice and as many splits as you like.
- **Bloodsworn:** every Hurt you take adds 3 steps to your action, and your Aura, with your action, brings your own wound die down a size for each you spend.
- **Elementalist:** one of your dice can be an area, a burst, a cone or a line, and it costs no Aura.
- **Face:** build your dice but don't roll them, and put them on a threat as influence. Roll them against one of its telegraphs before it lands, and each of its dice your best one beats does what you say.
- **Guardian:** you intercept blows for free, for every friend within your stride, whoever they're from.
- **Healer:** the only one who makes a heal roll, against the patient's wound die.
- **Hunter:** mark a creature, and anyone who acts against it rolls your Mark die too. When it falls, the Mark jumps to another.
- **Illusionist:** meet or beat the threats' Challenge, and they believe your illusion until they interact with it or try to get through it.
- **Leader:** an order or a rallying song hands its steps to friends who can hear or see you.
- **Maker:** roll against an item's size, and every die that beats it gives the item a tag for the scene.
- **Oracle:** roll your action as foresight, then swap those numbers into anyone's dice before the round ends, as long as each one fits the die.
- **Scholar:** win a Study and introduce a truth, a permission for the crew this scene.
- **Shadow:** the dice you hide with go into your shadow pool, to add to any roll after that.
- **Shifter:** catch animal tags against their die, and keep them until downtime.
- **Summoner:** the only one who catches souls and summons them.
- **Teleporter:** your stride can be a teleport of up to 10 units, and 1 Aura opens a portal.
- **Warrior:** your dice explode in a fight, so a top face rolls again and adds on.

Aura

- Up to your maximum, 5 to start. You're full every scene, and there's none in downtime.
- **Spend 1:** bring something in, a friend's permission through a thread too · keep a Catch quiet, or turn it your way · win a tie when you're acting · what 1 Aura gets your archetype · a quick heal · intercept for a friend within your stride.
- **Get 1 back:** every top face · letting a Catch bite, as often as you like, as long as it's real trouble · bringing real trouble on yourself with no Catch · a great setup that didn't land, if the GM says so · traits and Boons that say so.
- Traits are free, as often as they say, unless they say they cost Aura.

Resolve

- As much as you've got Titles, so 2 to start, and you can't hold more. The Resolve Boon makes it one more, and the Burden one fewer.
- **Spend 1:** an extra action this round · reroll a roll you just failed · go beyond what a permission normally does · hold your ground when fear, lies or pressure get through · go at a threat when you're shaken · your archetype's Resolve spend · in downtime, roll your own dice again.
- **Get 1 back:** at the end of every scene · when a Catch bites in a big way, changing the scene or costing you something you wanted (instead of the Aura, and it's your call when) · when the GM rewards great roleplay, like facing your fear · when you strain a thread.
- All of it comes back after downtime.

The round

1. **The GM telegraphs** everything, face up: what, at whom, how hard.
2. **Players act**, in any order, one action each.
3. **The round ends.** Unanswered telegraphs land, clocks and events nobody worked step down, and so does every condition.

Your action

- One a round: act, answer a telegraph, Defend, move past your stride, pull something from your bag, break a condition, take a breath (your Confidence comes up a size, as far as d6), or lead if you're a Leader. Your stride, a few words, and dropping something or putting it away are free. Intercepting costs 1 Aura but no action.
- **Extra actions:** hold it (just your stride this round) and you've got two next round · 1 Resolve · coming out of hiding, one even if you're *Unseen* as well · cashing in fired-up Confidence · the Boon, or a trait that says so.
- **Lead** (the Leader's): build an order or a rallying song and hand its steps to friends who can hear or see you, this round. They don't have to fit, and they don't bring a split.
- Outside a round, it's one action for a quick go, two if you can take your time.

Telegraphs and defence

- **Answer:** your action against its dice, built from what fits how you stop it, and friends can join in. Win and it's stopped. Lose and it lands at once, with no defence roll. A tie's a loss unless you pay 1 Aura. You can answer for a friend, and if you stepped in the way and lose, it lands on you.
- **Let it ride:** whatever you don't answer lands at the end of the round. Roll your Defend once against the blows and your Confidence once against the fear, lies and pressure, and each die stops one telegraph it beats or ties. Everything else gets through. A defence past 6 steps is more than one die, and each one stops one.
- **Defend:** your action. When they land, every line on your Defend counts twice, and you can split it once. A condition's step still counts once, and your Confidence rolls as it is. More dice stop more.
- **Intercept:** 1 Aura and no action. Take the blows aimed at a friend within your stride, and your own Defend handles them. A Guardian does it free, for every friend within his stride, and so does a summon. Nobody can intercept fear, lies or pressure.
- **One die at each of you** from each threat, unless a tag like *Flurry* says it can do more.
- **Running doesn't dodge.** One aimed at you lands wherever you've gone. Only one aimed at a place can be walked out of.
- At a stake, a place or a clock there's no defence. Unanswered, it happens.

Consequences: the GM names one

A Hurt · Confidence down (for a miss, where it fits) · break something you carry, like your armour or your shield (attuned things can't break) · Aspiration down · Party Goal down · a clock ticks. You can offer another that fits and costs about as much. A specific intent happens unless you trade it for one of these. A one-answer telegraph can't be traded.

When fear, lies or pressure get through, your Confidence drops a size instead, or 1 Resolve holds your ground (see Confidence).

Conditions

- A tag with a die, the die that placed it, for you or against you. Passive: one step, or for a few, like *Prone* and *Exposed*, a vulnerability. Active: spend it, free, for its big effect.
- A condition you put on a friend, like a ward or a blessing, goes on one friend at the die you built. The second die of a split can put it on another friend you can touch.
- It steps down a size every round, and it's gone past d2. Break it with an action that beats its die. One of each on a target, and the same one goes on once a round. Placed again later, the new one replaces it.
- On a threat, spending *Burning*, *Bleeding* or *Poisoned* strips a tag with no roll (on a multiplier, it ticks one off), and a lost action is a telegraph gone.
- *Marked* is the Hunter's. It gives no step and nobody spends it: anyone who acts against whatever's *Marked* rolls the Mark die too. When what it's on falls, the Mark jumps to another creature the Hunter can see.

3 Rolling

Building the die

- Pick the set action that fits how you're doing it. It's 1 step for the action and 1 for every line on it. Leave out a line that doesn't fit this time.
- Anything else that fits is 1 Aura each to bring in. Going beyond what a permission normally does is 1 Resolve, sword or spell.
- Two sides a step, up to a d12. Past 6 steps, build a second die the same way. Nothing fits, not even a Title? It's a d2.
- After you roll, 1 Aura puts your archetype's +2 on one die of its mechanic, if you need it.
- Every sheet has Defend, Fight, Move, Sneak, Study and Talk, and you add your own, like Locks or Ward. Titles, items and traits go on every one they fit nearly every time. A permission goes on two at most, Defend included, and the same one never goes on one set action twice.

STEPS	DICE
1 step	d2
2 steps	d4
3 steps	d6
4 steps	d8
5 steps	d10
6 steps	d12
7 steps	d12+d2
8 steps	d12+d4
9 steps	d12+d6
10 steps	d12+d8
11 steps	d12+d10
12 steps	2d12
18 steps	3d12
24 steps	4d12

The roll

- You roll the threat's die too, in another colour. The GM almost never rolls in a round.
- A threat rolls its defence once a round, the first time anyone goes at it, and every die at it that round has to beat that roll.
- **Beat it:** you did it. **Tie:** the defender wins (you when it lands on you, them when you act), but if you're acting, answering included, 1 Aura wins it. An Illusionist meets or beats. **Under:** you didn't, and it only costs you when it matters.
- **Top face:** 1 Aura back per die. Full? Give it to someone in the scene. A die the archetype's +2 took there doesn't count, and nor does a summon's or a number an Oracle swapped in.
- **Failed?** 1 Resolve rerolls it, all your dice or just one. The threat's dice stay where they landed.

Intents

- Every die gets an intent and a target before you roll. Several dice on one intent is advantage: your best die counts. Dice never add, except when you move, when a Warrior's dice explode, and the archetype's +2.
- **Splits:** one for every action in the roll, and one more past 6 steps, so 8 steps on one action can be a d6, a d6 and a d4. Dice past 6 steps are already separate, each with its own intent. You can share your steps between the dice you've got.
- **Area** (the Elementalist's): one die can be how far instead of an intent: a burst (that many squares out from a point), a cone (that long, and as wide at the end) or a line (twice as far). It takes a split and costs no Aura, and you can always make it smaller. No grid: 1 to 2 is close, 3 to 5 a few steps, 6 or more the whole room. *Sweep* weapons get one die at everyone in reach, free, whoever's holding them.

Combos

- **Combo:** two or more actions into the same thing at the same time, yours or your friends'. Add the set actions and roll once, with no Aura. The same line from one of you counts once, but the same permission from two of you counts for each. Whoever rolls takes the Aura for every top face. Your own extra action brings in another set action (Fight with Sneak), or the same one again for +1.

4 Threats, moving and gear

Moving

- Stride 3, free, before, between or after your action. A Move action rolls whatever makes you fast here, plus the action, for extra squares, and those dice add. A Teleporter's stride can be a teleport of up to 10 units.
- Difficult ground costs 2 a square. Diagonals count as one. There are no opportunity attacks. Cover is line of sight, and it doesn't add steps.
- Close 1 · Reach 2 · Near · Far · Beyond. No grid? Close, Reach and Near are within your stride, Far takes a Move action, and Beyond takes more than a round.
- Weapon properties: Reach · Thrown · Ranged · Long · Grapple · Sweep · Piercing · Breaker · Charge · Concealed · Quick · Two-Handed · Reload.

Threats

- Challenge 2 (d4) nuisance · 3 (d6) a real fight · 4 (d8) capable · 5 (d10) serious · 6 (d12) the top. It defends and telegraphs with its Challenge die, and that never steps down unless a tag says so. A tag only changes dice when it says so.
- Keeps-it-going tags are its health, and a multiplier, like *Armoured ×4*, is how many wins one takes. Mook: none or one. Named: two. Boss: three or more, multipliers on the big ones, and a weak point. *(first)* means nothing under it can be stripped till it's gone. *Layered* (special encounters only): one die for every one left, rolled the first time it's attacked in a round, and the best one stands.
- A win: strip a tag, or tick one off its multiplier · take it down · a condition · move it · learn something · stop a telegraph. An opening: one win ends a Mook or Named, and a Boss loses two whole tags (only its weak point ends it).
- **Vulnerabilities:** each one that fits a win that strips a tag or causes a Hurt adds one more tick, and you choose where it goes: the same tag, or another one the hit could reach, so one vulnerability can strip two plain tags. The same one never counts twice. *Prone* and *Exposed* are vulnerabilities, and a hidden one's a hidden tag.
- **Forms:** when a form's last keeps-it-going tag goes, it changes. It takes 3 to 5 tags from its Forms list, and its multipliers come back on whichever of them matter most. Its weak point ends it in any form.

Study

Roll against its Challenge. Win, and pick one: a hidden tag · a straight answer. A Scholar can introduce a truth instead: say something that wasn't obvious to anyone else, and it's true, and it counts as a permission for the crew this scene.

Stakes, clocks, events

- A stake: Challenge + tags in the way. Strip them all and it's yours.
- A clock steps down each round nobody works the stake. An event steps down each round nobody touches it. Past d2, it happens.
- Every scene gets a scene clock: past d2, the scene turns.

Chases

The Gap (past d2: caught, past d12: away) · The Pursuer (past d2: shaken off) · The Ground (past d2: the world wins). The Gap and the Ground step down each round unless someone changed them.

What you carry

- 3 equipment (what you wear or wield), 3 utility (tools, and things you use up and cross off) and a keepsake. A bag holds 10 more. Getting something out takes your action, and putting it away's free.
- A plain item's a line when it fits, and each piece of plain armour, and a shield, is a line on your Defend. A purse of gold is a utility item, about a month's wages.
- **Attunement:** one attuned thing to start, on top of what you carry, and attuned things can't break. Awakened: 1 permission, or 2 with a Catch. Tempered: 2, or 4 with a Burden. Perfected: 3, or 6 with a Burden and a Catch. Each stage needs a material, and each new permission a downtime slot.

Summoning

- Only a Summoner catches souls and summons them. A summoning attunement holds souls on the same ladder: 1 at Awakened (2 with a Catch), 2 at Tempered (4 with a Burden), 3 at Perfected (6 with a Burden and a Catch). Starting souls are d4s.
- **Catch one:** when a creature falls, spend your action and roll your Summon dice against its Challenge. Beat it and its soul goes in a utility slot, and into your attunement in downtime. Miss and it's gone.
- **Call them out:** your action, with a reason in the story. Each of your Summon dice brings out one soul whose die it beats. 1 Aura is +2 on one die, and +3 if you've taken Summoner twice.
- A summon acts like anyone and rolls its own die. One hit sends it back to its slot. It intercepts for free: it rolls its die to stop one of the dice it took, the first that gets through takes it out, and the rest go on to whoever they were aimed at. At the end of the scene, roll its die, and on 3 or lower it goes back. They all go back at downtime. Summons can't combo, and their top faces don't give Aura.